

Why some interpretable deviations count as ungrammatical: linguistic norms and levels of explanation

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Abstract

I develop an account of why some readily interpretable deviations count as ungrammatical while others count as lexical, phonological, orthographic, stylistic, pragmatic, or social. The account combines a practice-based theory of linguistic norms with a functional analysis of how signs, exponents, and values are assembled in recurrent constructions. I use French article elision, English inflection and complementation, register and honorific choice, and switch-reference to illustrate the analysis. It separates grammatical faults from recoverable meanings, unintended messages, and downstream judgments or sanctions. It also yields two testable predictions: independently identified assembly failures should attract more consistent assembly-directed attribution than matched neighbouring faults, and paradigms with stronger discourse consequences should produce larger differences between value-directed and form-directed repair.

Keywords: grammaticality; linguistic norm; form–value assembly; fault attribution; semantic repair; discourse consequence

AI USE. The large language models Claude Opus 4.5 and Claude Fable; a preview model with no disclosed developer or underlying-model identity, accessed through OpenCode Zen in August 2026; ChatGPT 5.2 Pro; and GPT-5.5 served as drafting and editing aids throughout the preparation of this paper. I am responsible for all theoretical claims, arguments, errors, and interpretive choices.

I THE SELECTIVE-CLASSIFICATION PROBLEM

In ordinary connected Reference French, *hiver* ‘winter’ begins with H MUET, and the singular definite article undergoes elision: *l’hiver*, not **le hiver* (Boersma, 2007). The deviant form remains easy to understand. Simonenko and Carlier (2020) treat the modern French *l*-forms as definite determiners; *le* still presents the noun phrase as masculine, singular, and definite. The problem lies in how that article is realized before this class of noun. The deviation is neither a wrong referent nor a failure to communicate definiteness. It also need not be treated as a general defect in French sound shape. The disputed relation belongs to the realization of the article construction.

This small example poses a general question. Why do some interpretable departures count as grammar while others count as semantic anomaly, poor wording, pronunciation, spelling, style, or social conduct? Meaninglessness can't mark the boundary: **le hiver*, **goed*, and many agreement errors are transparent. Expressive substance can't mark it either. Tone, intonation, word order, gesture, and segmental morphology can realize grammatical contrasts, while the same substances can distinguish words, accents, and styles. An asterisk records a classification; it doesn't yet explain that classification.

Six questions have to be separated. STATUS CONSTITUTION asks what makes a conventional relation grammatical rather than lexical, phonological, graphic, stylistic, pragmatic, or social. TOKEN APPLICATION asks whether a particular token conforms to that relation. SEMANTIC OR PRAGMATIC CONSEQUENCE asks what happens to composition, reference, force, commitment, or continuity. TARGET ATTRIBUTION asks what a respondent treats as having failed. RESPONSE CAUSATION asks why that respondent rejected, corrected, accommodated, ignored, or sanctioned the token. EPISTEMIC JUSTIFICATION asks what evidence warrants the analyst's answers. The questions concern five bearers because target and cause are distinct questions about the same public response.

This paper begins with status constitution. Within a scoped repertoire, a grammatical norm is a socially sustained relation among signs, exponents, or values in a recurrent construction. A VALUE is a conventional semantic, relational, structural, or discourse-organizing alternative selected or realized within a constructional domain. Such a norm supplies standards for whether a performance is a conforming or defective instance of that construction.

A lexical convention can instead establish the identity and content of a sign; phonotactics can constrain permissible sound shapes; orthography can represent an independently identified expression; and a usage norm can govern which licensed expression or persona fits an occasion. These roles can overlap, and their boundaries can be layered or unstable. Their differences are functional, not differences of substance or social importance.

This answer is norm-relative without making whatever people approve correct by definition. The paper targets public, repertoire-relative grammatical status, specified by community, activity, medium, and period. Such status is sustained in linguistic practice, but isn't identical to frequency, an explicit rule, a majority vote, or any one speaker's knowledge. Individual systems and formal grammars supply related targets whose conclusions don't transfer automatically to the public repertoire.

Scope can be refined during norm identification from outcome-blind evidence about interaction and exposure networks, activity, medium, period, institutional or register setting, and positive production and interpretation distributions. It's then frozen before target-attribution, correction, or repair outcomes are examined. When independently reasonable scopes support different results, grammatical status is scope-sensitive or unsettled at the broader scope; the analyst can't select the scope that recovers a preferred verdict.

The account uses an ASSEMBLY-ROLE PROFILE only as an epistemic instrument. Production, interpretation, substitution, omission, productivity, contrast structure, and distribution across a scoped repertoire provide evidence about how a candidate relation is organized. The estimate can be uncertain or wrong. Grammar labels, corrections, and repairs are withheld when constructing it because those responses are later evidence about whether speakers track the norm and what consequences its failure has. Held-out prediction constrains the account; it doesn't constitute grammatical status.

Two held-out predictions supply that constraint. An assembly role estimated without response labels should predict more consistent spontaneous attribution to expression assembly in held-out cases than matched lexical, phonotactic, representational, and deployment norms. Explicit grammar labels provide a further response measure and can diverge from assembly-directed attribution. Among independently identified grammatical paradigms, a separate discourse-consequence profile should predict the repair-locus difference between internal value conflicts and value-preserving realization failures.

The argument proceeds from objects to evidence. Section 2 separates the explanatory levels. Section 3 develops the ontology of grammatical norms and compares it with paradigmatic and discursive-status accounts. Section 4 distinguishes ways in which a token can fail. Section 5 locates semantic and pragmatic explanations, and Section 6 tests the account against boundary cases. Section 7 states the empirical consequences and conditions under which the proposal should be rejected or divided.

2 FIVE LEVELS, SIX EXPLANATORY QUESTIONS

The word “grammaticality” is used for objects at several levels. A formal theory licenses a representation; a community sustains a linguistic norm; a token conforms or fails to conform; a speaker issues a judgment; and an experimenter records a rating. Treating these as measurements of one latent yes–no property hides the dependence relations that need explanation. Table 1 separates the principal bearers.

Level	Bearer	Question
Norm architecture	a recurrent form–value relation in a scoped repertoire	what makes the relation grammatical rather than lexical, phonological, graphic, stylistic, or social?
Token status	a performance analyzed relative to that relation	which relation, if any, does the performance fail to conform to?
Semantic or pragmatic consequence	the interpreted utterance or communicative act	what happens to composition, reference, force, commitment, continuity, or response possibilities?
Public response	a judgment, correction, repair, accommodation, or sanction	what did this person or institution target? What caused that response?
Epistemic access	corpora, elicitation, substitutions, judgments, repairs, and models	what warrants the analyst’s claims about the other levels?

Table 1: Levels that a theory of selective grammaticality has to keep distinct.

The levels are connected, but they don’t form a single causal chain. At the time of an utterance, a norm constrains token status, and token status can affect interpretation and response. Processing load, mishearing, task demands, schooling, stigma, and institutional authority can also affect response without altering the token’s grammatical status. Over longer periods, production, accommodation, correction, and sanction can help maintain or change the repertoire. That diachronic feedback doesn’t make a particular response the truth-maker of the norm to which it reacts.

Each level also calls for a different kind of explanation. A CONSTITUTIVE EXPLANATION says what makes a relation a grammatical norm and what makes a token defective relative to it. A FUNCTIONAL EXPLANATION says what work the relation does in assembling expressions or organizing

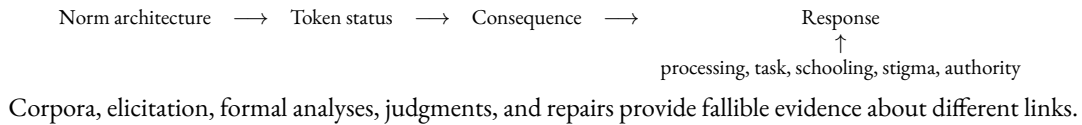


Figure 1: The main explanatory dependencies. Recurrent practice and response can feed back into norm architecture over historical time, but token-level response is not constitutive of status.

discourse. A semantic or pragmatic explanation says why an attempted combination is coherent, anomalous, repairable, or consequential.

An attributional explanation identifies which relation a public response treats as failed. A causal explanation says why a particular person reacted. An epistemic justification says why an analyst should believe any of these claims. Predictive success can strengthen that justification, but a black-box classifier of the word “grammar” wouldn’t thereby supply the constitutive explanation.

The source-ambiguity literature establishes the need for this separation at the response level. Hofmeister et al. (2013) show that a low acceptability rating doesn’t identify whether grammar, processing, interpretation, or contextualization caused it. Leivada and Westergaard (2020) likewise document dissociations between acceptability and grammaticality. These are constraints on the use of judgments as evidence. They don’t by themselves determine which worldly relation a respondent is trying to classify.

Nor does a formal derivation settle the matter. A theory can undergenerate a community-licensed pattern or generate one that the target repertoire doesn’t sustain. Conversely, a descriptive grammar may record a robust relation without explaining why it belongs to grammar rather than a neighbouring domain. Poulsen (2012, pp. 12–20) treats corpus distributions, processing measures, and judgments as indirect evidence for relatively stable conventional knowledge. The linguistic object, its representation, and the evidence for it remain separate even when a good theory brings them into alignment.

3 WHAT MAKES A NORM GRAMMATICAL?

The proposal starts from a broad semiotic inventory but individuates norms by their roles. Goldberg (1995) and Sag (2012) treat words, idioms, partly filled patterns, and abstract constructions as conventional form–meaning pairings. This ontology prevents an easy grammar–lexicon split: both a word and a schematic construction pair expression with content. It also makes the present question unavoidable. What distinguishes the relations that constitute grammatical assembly from other conventions in the same inventory?

3.1 PRACTICE-DEPENDENT, RESPONSE-INDEPENDENT STANDARDS

A linguistic norm is more than a frequent event type. It supplies a standard against which novel or disputed tokens can conform or fail to conform. Low-token- frequency constructions can be securely licensed, while frequent innovations can remain restricted or unstable. A norm needn’t be explicitly represented as a rule, prescribed by an institution, morally obligatory, or identically stored by every speaker. It’s socially sustained when production and interpretation converge on a relation, participants rely on it in forming and understanding new tokens, and counterfactual substitutions or omissions make systematic differences within a scoped repertoire.

Coseriu (1952) supplies a precedent. His distinction among system, norm, and speech separates functional possibilities, customary social realization, and individual production. Later presentations also distinguish congruence, idiomatic correctness, and situational appropriateness (Pardo Llibrer, 2021; Soto Vergara, 2022). This account inherits the idea that correctness relative to a historical language and appropriateness in a situation are different evaluative relations. It adds a question that Coseriu's distinctions don't settle on their own: which role within the linguistic repertoire makes the relevant norm grammatical?

The paper explicates public repertoire status for conventional fault attribution and descriptive grammar. Other legitimate targets for "grammaticality" remain. Psycholinguistic accounts can model individual competence and innovations not yet sustained more widely. A formal grammar can model an idiolect or a public variety. In each case, derivability establishes status relative to that model and target; it doesn't by itself establish public licensing. Conversely, speakers can reliably follow a public relation without consciously representing, correcting, or institutionally enforcing it. Individual, model-relative, and public claims can inform one another, but none is a proxy for the others (Leivada & Westergaard, 2020; Poulsen, 2012).

The answer is functional. A grammatical norm relates already individuated signs, exponents, or values within recurrent constructions. It can govern the filling of a constructional position, the selection or combination of relational values, the satisfaction of an obligatory contrast, or the realization of a selected value. These standards govern whether a performance conforms to the relations required by that construction.

Other norms can instead establish the identity of a sign, constrain its possible sound shape, map it into writing, or govern the deployment of an already licensed expression. Words and phrases can both host the relevant relations. The functional contrast separates establishing or shaping a linguistic sign from relating signs, exponents, or values in a recurrent constructional token.

Three objects have to remain distinct: an utterance or inscription, its recoverable affiliation with a construction, and its conformity or defect relative to each constructional relation. Material can remain identifiable as a defective instance through the relations it preserves while failing another relation required for conformity. An ungrammatical performance needn't disappear from the ontology merely because it isn't a conforming instance.

The functional distinction has to be justified independently of the labels it's expected to predict. The justification has four parts. First, the motivating contrasts are relational: the same degree of interpretability and the same expressive substance can receive different classifications depending on what the departure disrupts. Second, a constructional inventory already contains lexical signs, phonological forms, and social-indexical resources. Being conventional or meaningful doesn't by itself establish grammatical status. A further role is needed for relations that organize those resources into recurrent expression types, within or above the word.

Third, that role supports a counterfactual test. Hold lexical identities, the intended constructional values, and the situation of use fixed. If changing the candidate relation changes whether the recoverably affiliated material conforms to the recurrent construction, the relation contributes to grammatical assembly. If the change affects only possible sound shape, graphic representation, or situational fit, a neighbouring norm is at issue. Finally, recurrent reliance on the relation within a scoped practice makes this constructional standard a norm rather than a one-off regularity.

Miller (2021) provides a near precedent rather than a complete argument. He treats word in-

stances as governed by community-relative local performance standards, sustained by external social mechanisms while internal mechanisms enable the production of new instances. This makes the standards conditions on conforming word instances, not summaries of observed frequencies. Miller leaves the nature of those standards open, and stable clustering can't by itself supply normativity.

The bridge proposed here is constitutive reliance. Its synchronic dependence base is a distributed pattern of practical reliance: appropriately situated participants are disposed to produce and interpret novel performances through the relation, those dispositions are sufficiently coordinated for the relation to support constructional conformity, and counterfactual substitutions or omissions systematically alter that conformity. Corpus distributions, elicitation, and responses provide evidence about this pattern without constituting it.

Correctness is thin and practice-internal. A performance is correct or defective relative to a repertoire insofar as it conforms or fails to conform to a standard for constructing or realizing expressions. This needn't amount to moral obligation, institutional approval, actual correction, majority preference, or statistical expectedness. Transmission, teaching, correction, and repair can maintain the norm through time without forming part of its synchronic dependence base. A token-level judgment may misidentify the defect, and the absence of correction doesn't remove it. An innovation can be surprising while conforming to an existing construction, whereas a familiar shibboleth can attract condemnation without any assembly failure. Constructional role supplies grammar-specificity by locating the standard in relations among signs, exponents, or values.

The test need not force every case into one box. Lexical valence can partly determine whether an argument construction is licensed, and item-specific allomorphy can realize a grammatical value. Such cases contain more than one relation. What the test forbids is inferring the relation from a respondent's preferred metalinguistic word. Its independent inputs are sign identity, conventional value, constructional role, and scope.

Norm type	Governing role	Characteristic fault
Grammatical assembly	signs, exponents, or values are related within recurrent constructions	a constructional relation, selected value, obligatory contrast, or licensed realization fails
Lexical sign identity and content	a conventional sign has an identity and contributes lexical content	a purported word form realizes no conventional lexeme, violates an independently supported lexical relation, or contributes nonconventional lexical content
Phonological form formation	sound, syllable, prosodic, or possible word-form shape	expression shape fails without a constructional value relation failing
Graphic representation	an independently identified linguistic expression is represented in writing	spelling or graphic convention fails while linguistic assembly remains intact
Usage and social deployment	a licensed expression, repertoire, persona, or act fits an occasion	assembly succeeds but situational or social fit fails
Institutional metalinguistic classification	a school, editor, or prestige institution applies a correctness category	the label can accurately or inaccurately target any preceding relation

Table 2: Functional norm types. The rows can intersect in one token rather than partitioning expressive substances.

Table 2 excludes pure phonotactics from grammar in the target sense. A pure phonotactic norm constrains the well-formedness of a sound shape independently of any contrast among constructional values. A phonological relation enters grammatical assembly only when conditioned by, or when realizing, a grammatical choice. Tone can realize tense or clause type; a harmony pattern can form part of the realization of a switch-reference value; and allomorphy can realize a determiner or inflectional

value. What matters is the role of the relation, not whether its exponent is segmental, tonal, gestural, or absent.

The distinction also permits mixed cases. An item-specific complement restriction can participate in a grammatical valence construction and in lexical knowledge about a particular head. An honorific system can organize a recurrent constructional choice while also indexing persona and relationship. A spelling contrast can become grammatically relevant if a writing system conventionally uses it to realize a grammatical value. These intersections don't show that all linguistic norms are grammatical. They show that grammatical status belongs to a relation in a role and scope, not to a substance or word considered in isolation.

3.2 INDIVIDUATING THE ASSEMBLY RELATION

The phrase "already individuated" doesn't mean already classified as lexical or grammatical. A candidate sign is supported when a form-value contribution recurs across combinations; a bound exponent can instead be identified by recurrent opposition to other realizations in the same conditioned position. A candidate construction is supported when a distribution and interpretation recur under substitution, omission, or embedding. These criteria identify possible *relata* and *sites* without using judgments about which fault domain they belong to.

A relational analysis then has to predict more than the stored identity of a larger sign. Its participants recur or contrast independently, and varying one of them reveals a dependency over an independently motivated position, value, or class. The proposed decomposition should also predict behaviour in further substitutions, derived forms, or constructional environments that wasn't used to posit it. Structural separability, productivity, and preservation of contribution across frames can all supply such evidence. None is necessary on its own: a construction can be item-restricted or contain fixed material.

A whole-sign analysis is favoured when the supposed parts don't preserve their contributions outside the expression and the proposed internal relation predicts nothing beyond an item list. The relevant grain is comparative. Competing whole-sign and relational analyses are evaluated by how much independently observed distribution and interpretation they capture without adding a dependency solely for the disputed case. If the evidence supports both analyses equally, the grain is epistemically indeterminate. If speakers or situations sustain different organizations, the repertoire itself is unsettled at the declared scope. Neither result licenses an automatic verdict of "partly grammatical".

Mixed analyses face a stricter requirement. Each recovered relation has to be attested outside the response being explained and has to make a distinct counterfactual prediction. Inflection inside an idiom, for example, can be separated from the idiom's lexical identity only where the inflectional relation recurs elsewhere and predicts changes within the idiom. Positing one grammatical and one lexical layer merely because respondents divide their labels would add no independent structure and is forbidden by the account.

English complementation and collocation illustrate the procedure. In *depend on an answer*, the verb, complement role, and complement fillers recur independently; related forms such as *dependence on* and *dependent on* preserve the head-specific preposition. This supports a licensing chain from argument role, through phrasal category, to an item-restricted realization. The higher links project across complement fillers and constructions, while the final *on* restriction remains close to lexical knowledge. Projection alone is insufficient because collocations and morphological families can also project. Relevant evidence includes preservation of argument role across fillers, participation in inde-

pendently motivated complement alternations, recurrence across derived forms, contrasts with non-argumental uses, and whether the preposition realizes a constructional relation or merely remains associated with a lexical family. On the evidence considered here, the argument-role and PP-category links are assembly relations; the final head–preposition restriction remains epistemically indeterminate between lexically indexed licensing and collocation.

In *heavy rain*, both words and the adjective–noun construction are also independently supported. Replacing *heavy* with *strong* can leave modification and ordinary composition intact while producing a less conventional lexical combination. On that analysis, the construction is licensed and the collocation is poor.

The comparison can reverse. If *depend on* behaves only as an unanalyzable stored expression and projects to no further frames, the constructional chain loses support. If *heavy* develops into a bleached intensity exponent over an independently supported class of nouns, its selection acquires an assembly role. The analysis is fixed from these distributional and interpretive facts before corrections or grammar labels are examined.

3.3 PARADIGMS, CONSTRUCTIONAL CHAINS, AND DISCURSIVE STATUS

Strict paradigms provide a strong case of grammatical assembly. Nørgård-Sørensen and Heltoft (2015) characterize a grammatical paradigm through a recurring domain, a language-specific semantic frame, a bounded set of alternatives, obligatory choice in the domain, and marked–unmarked organization. The architecture extends beyond inflection to word order and constructional syntax. Hansen and Heltoft (2011) likewise allow prototype and radial organization within their account of Danish grammar. These analyses show how a repertoire can organize a set of values and their realizations without reducing grammar to segmental morphology.

Paradigmhood doesn't define all grammar on this account. Constructional dependencies can be productive without a closed set of values, and item-specific links can form the lowest part of a more schematic licensing chain. The assembly-norm account places these relations by asking what they contribute to the formation of constructional tokens. Bounded alternatives, obligatoriness, and markedness are powerful ways of organizing that role, not universal conditions on it.

Boye and Harder (2012) offer a constitutive alternative. They make conventional ancillarity and discursive secondary status central to grammatical status, with focusability and addressability as diagnostics; closed paradigms and obligatoriness are incidental. Their proposal and this account agree that surface substance and simple frequency don't define grammar.

Their proposed identity condition differs from the present one. Constructional organization and discursive secondary status can in principle cross-classify where constructionally organized material remains independently focusable or addressable, or where conventionally ancillary material lacks an independently individuated assembly relation. Establishing such a case requires independent evidence for both properties; the diagnostics alone don't decide it. Discursive secondary status may prove a better general account. The dispute has to be decided by the range and organization of cases each analysis explains, not by entering the two labels into a regression and calling the higher coefficient constitutive.

3.4 GRADIENCE AND EPISTEMIC PROFILES

Grammatical status can be layered without making evidence, reality, and judgment equally fuzzy. A relation may participate only partly in a constructional chain, be item-restricted, compete with a

Account	Constitutive centre	Pressure point
Strict paradigm architecture	bounded alternatives in a recurring domain and semantic frame, obligatory selection, and markedness	construction-sized and item-restricted dependencies that lack a strict paradigm
Boye–Harder	conventional ancillarity and discursive secondary status	possible cross-classification between constructional organization and focusability, addressability, or ancillarity
Assembly norm	socially sustained form–value organization internal to recurrent constructional tokens	lexical valence, morphophonology, and social-indexical constructions that occupy mixed roles

Table 3: Three constitutive proposals. Their diagnostics can supply evidence, but the dispute concerns what grammatical status consists in.

more open lexical choice, or be conventional in one activity and unstable in another. This variation is world-side gradience in the role and scope of the norm. Evidence for the relation can independently be strong or weak. A respondent can independently issue a categorical or hesitant label. A sharp schoolroom correction doesn't prove a sharply grammatical relation, just as uncertain corpus evidence doesn't prove a fuzzy norm.

An assembly-role profile is the analyst's estimate of the first of these objects. It records evidence about three questions: whether form and value are coupled at a constructional site, how alternatives and selection are organized, and how the relation is licensed across the declared repertoire. Production, interpretation, substitution, omission, productivity, and opportunity-normalized distribution bear on those questions. A descriptive grammar contributes through the evidence it reports, not by lending the analysis its prior category label.

The profile keeps grounds, indicators, and outcomes separate. Assembly role is the proposed constitutive basis; choice architecture organizes the relation; community licensing fixes its social existence and scope; distributional patterns provide evidence and can help stabilize the practice; formal analyses represent it; and judgments or repairs are fallible downstream evidence. This ordering is what permits the paper to say that a respondent can be wrong rather than merely outvoted.

4 HOW TOKENS FAIL LINGUISTIC NORMS

Once a candidate norm and its scope have been identified, token application asks which relation the token fails. Several questions that are often compressed into one asterisk should be distinguished.

The rows don't form a sequence through which every token passes. Coverage, compatibility, saturation, value selection, realization, and licensing locate different possible relations between a token and a scoped repertoire. They also separate two senses of "form error". A string can violate pure phonotactics, in which case its expression shape is the target. Or the repertoire can exclude a phonological form as the realization of a grammatical value, in which case a grammatical assembly relation is at issue.

Value errors require particular care. Three cases have to remain separate.

1. An INTERNAL VALUE INCOMPATIBILITY arises when linguistic material in the token supplies values that conflict: agreement features disagree, a temporal construction conflicts with an overt temporal specification, or a switch-reference marker conflicts with the represented subjects of its clause chain. This can be a grammatical failure.
2. In EXTERNAL VALUE MISAPPLICATION, a licensed grammatical value is successfully encoded but is false, misleading, or inappropriate for the described situation. A yesterday-past form used for

an event that actually happened today need not be ungrammatical.

3. In a MESSAGE-SELECTION ERROR, a speaker chooses a grammatical competitor that doesn't express the intended message. The production is mistaken, but the resulting expression can remain grammatical.

Question	Possible failure	Illustration	Primary locus
Conditioning	the wrong repertoire, activity, medium, or period has been assumed	formal versus informal usage	scope
Coverage	no viable constructional assembly analyzes the supplied material	recoverable intended question with no licensed constructional analysis	construction
Compatibility	linguistically supplied instructions conflict	<i>*These books is useful</i>	internal value relation
Saturation	an obligatory contrast or constructional role remains unsupplied	omitted obligatory marker or argument	assembly
Value selection	a constructional competitor conflicts with another linguistically supplied value	same-subject marker with distinct represented subjects	internal value relation
Realization	the intended constructional value is preserved but its exponent or surface form is excluded	<i>*le hiver; *goed</i>	grammatical form
Constructional licensing	a transparent combination is absent from the scoped repertoire	<i>*depend of</i> + OBJ	valence or collocation
Non-assembly target	linguistic assembly succeeds but content, spelling, persona, situation, or conduct is at issue	register mismatch; misspelling	neighbouring norm

Table 4: Token-level questions. A single response can target more than one row, and the cause of that response remains a separate question.

Of these three value cases, only internal incompatibility establishes a grammatical fault by itself. The distinction follows from the constitutive account: grammaticality concerns conformity to the relations that assemble the linguistic token, not direct correspondence between that token and the world or the speaker's private intention. Semantic and pragmatic theories are needed to explain those further relations.

Selecting a poor but licensed word supplies the lexical analogue. The sign keeps its conventional identity and meaning, and the surrounding construction can be well formed; the selected content is simply inapt. A register mismatch can likewise preserve the proposition and the form's conventional social-indexical value while deploying that value in an unsuitable situation. These choices may be serious, accountable, or sharply sanctioned. Their social importance doesn't move the failed relation into grammatical assembly.

5 WHAT SEMANTIC AND PRAGMATIC EXPLANATIONS EXPLAIN

Semantic and pragmatic theory enter the architecture twice. First, the content of a grammatical relation can be semantic, relational, or discourse-organizing. Tense, definiteness, evidential source, clause type, reference continuity, and commitment can all be values organized by recurrent constructional choices. Second, semantic or pragmatic theory can explain what happens when an attempted combination conflicts, remains underspecified, invites coercion, or alters a conversation. The first role helps specify the norm; the second explains a consequence of conformity or failure.

5.1 SEMANTIC REPAIRABILITY

Abrusán (2019, pp. 329–331, 344–348) asks why failed interpretation can produce semantic anomaly, pragmatic infelicity, or ungrammaticality. Abrusán et al. (2021) develop a substantive answer in

terms of type level, locality, and semantic shift. Local conflicts involving lower-level, context-shiftable types can leave a recoverable predication, whereas conflicts involving constitutive high-level types can be nonlocal and resist meaning-preserving repair. Because the type architecture and shift possibilities are independently motivated, the account explains rather than merely relabels an important classification boundary.

Its scope is also informative. Semantic repairability can explain cases in which composition or interpretation supplies the trouble. It doesn't by itself determine whether French article non-elision, a suppletive past form, a phonotactic violation, or a spelling error belongs to grammar. Those cases can be transparent precisely because semantic composition has largely succeeded. The assembly account and the repairability account overlap where grammatical norms organize semantic composition, but neither reduces to the other.

In its native domain, Abrusán's analysis can defeat an assembly-based explanation of the response or classification if type level and shiftability already account for it. The constitutive ontology is challenged only if the same resources also explained what makes the failed relation grammatical.

This division avoids making semantics external to grammar. A tense construction is grammatical partly because it conventionally assembles temporal value; a semantic theory explains that value. If two linguistically encoded temporal instructions conflict, semantic theory may also explain the anomaly. What it does not establish without a further premise is whether the convention that assembled those instructions belongs to grammar, lexical semantics, or a pragmatic practice.

5.2 DISCOURSE CONSEQUENCES WITHOUT A UNITARY PUBLIC STATE

Some grammatical choices conventionally configure discourse as well as propositional content. Heltoft (1981) separates grammaticality from comprehensibility in his treatment of epistemic verbs, and Heltoft (2005) distinguishes mood's illocutionary role from the interlocutionary role of dialogic particles. Hansen and Heltoft (2011) and Jakobsen and Heltoft (2012) extend the connection between paradigmatic organization and discourse function. Interactional research likewise treats grammar as a resource for sequential action and repair (Dingemanse et al., 2014; Fox et al., 1996; Muntigl & Ventola, 2010). These traditions show that grammatical organization can have public consequences. They don't make those consequences criteria for grammatical membership.

Nor should the consequences be represented as one scalar public record. Bary (2025) argues that common belief, discourse commitment, and real performative change have to be separated. Simons (2025) argues more radically that information appropriately used in interpretation need not be common ground and that a single body of information shouldn't serve as both the background to and target of speech acts. The account is compatible with either view. A DISCOURSE-CONSEQUENCE PROFILE records a vector: effects on move type, commitment holder or source, discourse-participant or referent continuity, and response relevance. It assumes no unitary public state and no universal weights among the components.

This profile describes a function of an independently identified grammatical choice. It isn't part of the definition of grammar. Clause type, evidential anchoring, and switch-reference are plausible high-consequence cases; ordinary allomorphy isn't. Interjections can strongly reshape uptake without forming grammatical paradigms (Ameka, 1992). Conversely, a grammatical agreement marker can be locally redundant even if its paradigm contributes to reference tracking across other occasions of use.

Where a paradigm independently supports both an internal value incompatibility and a value-preserving realization failure, the former should more often prompt clarification of force, commitment, role, or reference, while the latter should more often prompt form correction that preserves the intended discourse effect. Across paradigms, that difference should increase with the independently estimated discourse-consequence profile. The resulting hypothesis concerns repair locus downstream of grammatical status.

The information-theoretic intuition also belongs at the consequence level. Constrained alternatives create redundancy: a hearer may recover an intended value because the licensed competitors make the deviation detectable. Entropy or divergence can quantify how much choosing another value would alter a response space only after linguistic analysis supplies the alternatives (Cover & Thomas, 2006; Shannon, 1948). Information theory doesn't discover which alternatives form a grammatical paradigm, whether a token fails a form-value relation, or why a community treats that failure as accountable. The codebook is an input to the calculation, not its output.

6 BOUNDARY CASES AS TESTS OF THE ONTOLOGY

The boundary cases test whether the functional roles in Table 2 can be assigned from the organization of the relation before a respondent's label is known. Table 5 states the relevant contrasts.

Case	Candidate relation	Neighboring analysis	What would decide
<i>*le hiver</i>	conditioned realization of the definite-article construction	general phonological form formation or graphic convention	construction specificity, medium, lexical grouping, and elision distribution
<i>*goed</i>	realization of past value in an inflectional choice	lexeme-specific word form	productivity of the tense construction and item-specific pre-emption
<i>*depend of</i>	head-specific link in a complement and valence chain	lexical collocation	argument role, phrasal category, head restriction, and substitution pattern
Register or honorific mismatch	grammaticalized form-social-value choice or licensed social-indexical sign	situational deployment of an already licensed value	recurrence, constructional domain, alternative set, and whether assembly succeeds
Misspelling	graphic representation of a linguistic expression	grammatical realization in a writing-specific construction	whether the graphic contrast represents a sign or realizes a constructional value
Selectional anomaly	constructional compatibility relation	lexical-semantic or world-knowledge conflict	conventional locality, productivity, type level, and semantic repairability

Table 5: Adversarial boundary cases. The final column identifies evidence to be fixed independently of grammar labels and repairs.

6.1 FRENCH ARTICLE REALIZATION AND PURE PHONOTACTICS

The French example tests the distinction between form formation and grammatical realization. Borsma (2007, pp. 1989–1994) reports that the final vowel of singular *le* or *la* elides phrase-internally before a vowel-initial noun, remains before a consonant-initial noun, and also remains before an H ASPIRÉ noun. The prevocalic elision is obligatory in the described variety. These distributions provide positive evidence rather than a borrowed grammar label. Table 6 carries the reconstruction to the point at which its response prediction can be frozen.

Component	French elision reconstruction
Scope	contemporary ordinary connected Reference French, with speech primary and graphic realization analyzed separately
Relata and site	singular definite article values and their realizations before a vowel-initial or H MUET noun
Independent evidence	the <i>le/la/l'</i> opposition, preservation of definiteness and gender–number, phrase-internal distribution, and the contrasts with consonant-initial and H ASPIRÉ nouns
Assembly analysis	conditioned realization of a selected article value
Neighbouring analysis	general hiatus avoidance, phonotactic form formation, or graphic convention
Ontological defeater	outcome-blind distribution supports only a general form-shape relation and no construction-specific value–realization relation
Frozen prediction	value-preserving non-elision prompts more assembly-directed attribution than matched pure phonotactic or graphic failures
Predictive defeater	held-out responses systematically target phonology rather than article realization despite independent support for the assembly relation

Table 6: A qualitative assembly-role profile frozen before response outcomes. This isn't a completed held-out test.

The intended definite, masculine, singular value remains recoverable in **le hiver*. The analysis is neutral between deriving *l'* through vowel deletion and treating it as an allomorph. What matters is whether the article's selected value is coupled to a conditioned realization rather than whether two vowels happen to be adjacent.

The two defeat conditions belong to different levels. If outcome-blind distributional evidence supports only a general phonotactic relation, the constitutive grammatical analysis loses. If the assembly relation remains independently supported but respondents target phonology, the attribution prediction loses or needs qualification. Evidence for both relations warrants a layered analysis only when each relation is independently supported.

6.2 INFLECTION, COMPLEMENTATION, AND LEXICAL KNOWLEDGE

**Goed* conforms to the productive past-tense schema at one grain: past is realized by *-ed*. A more specific, lexeme-indexed relation realizes GO.PAST as *went* and pre-empts the general realization for this lexeme in the scoped repertoire. The form preserves past and satisfies the productive schema while failing the more specific realization relation. The layered analysis is supported independently by the productive schema and the stable lexeme-specific opposition. The exponent isn't intrinsically excluded; it's excluded for this lexeme.

**Depend of* applies the licensing chain developed in Section 3.2. A complement construction introduces an argument relation; that relation constrains a phrasal category; and the particular head restricts the preposition. The higher links are independently supported assembly relations. The present evidence doesn't settle whether the final *depend-on* restriction is lexically indexed licensing or collocation. Mixed attribution is informative only when compared with that independently specified chain and its stated indeterminacy.

The lexicon more generally contains conventional form–meaning pairings. Choosing an ill-fitting licensed word normally preserves the word's identity and the larger construction. Selectional restrictions and valence frames become harder because lexical content can constrain how a construction is assembled. Abrusán's type and shift diagnostics help determine whether a semantic conflict is doing the work; constructional recurrence and substitution show whether a conventional assembly relation is also present.

6.3 DEPLOYMENT, REPRESENTATION, AND GRAMMATICALIZATION

Register, accent, and Japanese polite/plain style can be highly systematic and socially consequential (Agha, 2007; Cook, 2008; Eckert, 2012; Ide, 2005). A mismatch may preserve the form’s conventional social value perfectly and fail only because that value is unsuitable for the occasion. In that case, assembly has succeeded and deployment is the fault. An honorific or style contrast can move toward grammatical assembly when a repertoire organizes it as a recurrent constructional choice with a domain, alternatives, and conditioned selection. The account doesn’t exclude pragmatic or social content from grammar in advance.

Orthography normally maps graphic forms to linguistic expressions. A misspelling can leave the relevant linguistic assembly intact. The boundary shifts where a writing system uses a graphic contrast to realize a constructional value. The medium doesn’t determine the norm type; the relation’s functional role does.

These possibilities are also diachronic. Grammaticalization can recruit lexical or pragmatic material into constructional and paradigmatic organization (Degand & Evers-Vermeul, 2015; Hopper & Traugott, 2003; Jakobsen & Heltoft, 2012; Lehmann, 2015; Waltereit, 2011). Historical origin doesn’t fix present status. The relevant question is which role the relation occupies in the scoped repertoire now.

6.4 A DISCOURSE-CONSEQUENCE APPLICATION

Amele switch-reference illustrates the narrower distinction between an internal value conflict and a value-preserving realization failure. Roberts (1987, pp. 239–240, 298–300, 371) describes a sequential paradigm contrasting same-subject (SS) and different-subject (DS) linkage on medial verbs, with person–number marking and vowel harmony in the DS form. For a second-person subject followed by a third-person subject, Table 7 gives a candidate comparison.

Condition	Amele form	Analysis
Licensed target	<i>Hina bo-co-m sab je-i-a</i>	‘You came and he ate the food’ (DS)
Constructed internal-conflict candidate	<i>Hina b-u-me-g sab je-i-a</i>	licensed 2sg SS form conflicts with the distinct represented subject of the following clause
Constructed realization-failure candidate	<i>Hina bo-ce-m sab je-i-a</i>	DS and 2sg material are retained, but the DS vowel is disharmonic after <i>bo-</i>

Table 7: A schematic Amele switch-reference comparison. The two candidate sequences are constructed from Roberts’s paradigm and haven’t been validated as judgments in the intended clause-chain context.

The first error condition is grammatical only if the subject information is linguistically represented in the clause chain and the SS value conflicts with it. A speaker who merely intends a different continuation after producing a well-formed SS chain has made a message-selection error instead. The realization condition preserves DS but violates the harmony relation described for its form.

Because SS and DS choice is sensitive to agentivity, clause level, time, place, world, and pragmatic deixis, those factors can’t be inferred from subject identity alone. The published grammar also

doesn't print the exact disharmonic stimulus. The comparison is a source-grounded template that requires validation, not an empirical result.

If the internal conflict is established, the two failures support different discourse predictions. An SS/DS conflict can unsettle reference continuity; a disharmonic realization need not. Whether participants direct repair to reference or form remains a separate causal and empirical question. The ontology permits this cross-level inference; it isn't evidence used to define the switch-reference relation as grammatical.

7 METHODOLOGICAL CONSEQUENCES AND DEFEAT CONDITIONS

The ontology changes what counts as evidence. A study can't identify a grammatical norm from the same grammar labels it later claims to explain. It first specifies a candidate relation and fixes or refines its scope from outcome-blind evidence about exposure, positive production and interpretation, substitution, omission, productivity, constructional embedding, contrast organization, and distribution. Scope is frozen before target-attribution, correction, or repair outcomes are examined. Where independently reasonable scopes yield different results, the analysis reports scope sensitivity rather than selecting the scope that recovers a preferred verdict. The resulting assembly-role profile is an estimate with visible components and uncertainty, not a universal score. Only then are new tokens or a disjoint corpus partition examined for judgments, corrections, repairs, or sanctions.

This order doesn't make judgments irrelevant. It prevents them from doing two incompatible jobs at once. Open descriptions and spontaneous corrections should precede forced choices among "grammar", "wording", "style", and related labels. A construction-directed response isn't automatically grammar-directed because lexical constructions are part of the boundary at issue. Mixed and unresolved responses remain visible. Explicit schoolroom terminology is analyzed separately from the relation a respondent appears to target.

The comparison set has to challenge the constitutive distinction. It should include strict paradigms, productive constructions, value-preserving realization failures, item-specific licensing chains, pure phonotactic and orthographic departures, poor but licensed lexical choices, social-indexical mismatches, and violations of social acts. The items should remain interpretable. If the assembly analysis is adjusted after the responses are known, the test has collapsed back into an account of labeling.

Rival explanations operate at different levels. Semantic reparability may explain classifications where composition fails. Boye and Harder's discursive secondary status may better identify grammatical norms. Frequency, surprisal, perceptual salience, and processing can cause low ratings or rapid correction. Schooling, stigma, participant role, and institutional authority can cause grammar-directed labels or person-directed sanction. Activity, medium, register, community, and period fix the population of the claim rather than serving as a bag of statistical controls. A good design restricts or matches these causes where possible and states which remaining comparison is identified.

Three empirical consequences then become available. First, relations estimated to occupy the grammatical assembly role more fully and robustly should elicit more consistent spontaneous assembly-directed attribution in held-out cases than lexical, phonotactic, representational, deployment, and social-act controls. Explicit grammar labels should correlate with that attribution, but the correlation is a further response-level prediction and may be weakened by schooling or local metalinguistic practice.

Second, independently layered or changing relations should produce variable or moving boundaries among grammar, lexicon, phonology, and style. Third, among paradigms that independently support both error types, a stronger discourse-consequence profile should increase the difference in update-directed repair between internal value conflicts and value-preserving realization failures.

These predictions are evidential consequences, not definitions. The constitutive account fails if its functional roles can't place phonotactics, lexical identity, representation, deployment, and mixed constructional cases without relying on the responses to be explained. Its empirical reach fails if independently estimated assembly organization adds no stable held-out expectation about fault attribution or boundary movement beyond semantic repairability, discursive secondary status, processing, schooling, and sanction. The discourse application fails if the independently estimated consequence profile doesn't predict the repair-locus difference in an identifying comparison.

Some outcomes are inconclusive rather than favourable or fatal. A corpus of corrections is selected for occasions on which someone corrected, so it can't by itself estimate how a community classifies all comparable tokens. Naturally occurring internal value conflicts and realization failures may also be too sparse or uneven for the repair comparison. Such data can test search procedures, coding, and candidate analyses without being promoted into a confirmatory result. The account earns support only from comparisons whose norm evidence and outcome evidence are separable in practice.

8 CONCLUSION

Why does one interpretable deviation count as ungrammatical while another does not? The answer proposed here begins with the relation that constitutes the norm. A grammatical norm is a socially sustained standard relating signs, exponents, or values within recurrent constructions in a scoped repertoire. A token is grammatically defective with respect to a relation when it fails to conform to it. The performance can remain recoverably affiliated with the construction through the relations it preserves. Recoverability doesn't erase the fault, and a negative response doesn't create it.

Other linguistic norms govern different roles. Lexical conventions establish sign identity and content; phonotactics constrains form shape; orthography ordinarily represents an independently identified expression; and usage norms govern the deployment of licensed resources. The boundaries don't partition substances. Phonological material can realize grammar, pragmatic values can become organized in paradigms, and item-specific knowledge can form part of a constructional chain. Mixed cases are expected, but each proposed layer has to recur or contrast independently and predict substitutions, derived forms, or environments. If unitary and relational analyses remain equally supported, the grain is indeterminate; a mixed label can't rescue the ontology.

The explanatory levels remain distinct. Semantic repairability explains an important subset of anomaly classifications. Discourse theory explains how some grammatical values affect move type, commitment, continuity, and response relevance. Processing and social theories explain why speakers detect, tolerate, correct, stigmatize, or misclassify tokens. Formal grammars and assembly-role profiles represent the relevant relations; they don't constitute them.

The motivating French case now has a precise role. **Le hiver* preserves definiteness and reference but uses an excluded realization of the article construction on the candidate analysis. It counts as a grammatical-form error only if that constructional relation, rather than pure phonotactics or graphic convention, is what fails in the scoped repertoire. That conditional is a strength: the theory can be wrong about the case without redefining grammar to save it.

The methodological consequence is equally direct. Evidence about a norm, token status, semantic or pragmatic consequence, target attribution, and response cause have to be allowed to disagree. Independent profiling and held-out response are ways to test whether the proposed ontology has reach, not substitutes for the ontology. If assembly role can't distinguish the difficult boundary cases without recycling their labels, the constitutive answer fails and the narrower theory of metalinguistic attribution is all that remains.

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